OCEAN LITERACY BRIEF #3

Blue citizens, better decisions: How people and leaders can bring rivers and the ocean into democratic life[1]

Key recommendations:

1. Make sure local democratic processes listen to what people think and feel about rivers and the ocean.

2. Create more opportunities, such as events, digital tools and workshops, that explain the rights and responsibilities of citizens, companies and public decision makers for river and ocean sustainability.

3. Support mayors and local councillors to host regular discussions in aquariums, museums, town halls and other public places so people can learn about the ocean and share their views.

4. Put river and ocean issues higher on the political agenda and set up inclusive governance mechanisms that actively involve citizens in shaping ocean strategies and decisions

What we mean by ocean sustainability

Our reference to ocean sustainability and ocean literacy implies a full source-to-sea perspective. This means looking at the whole system, from inland rivers and lakes through estuaries and coasts to the open ocean. It also means involving all actors, whether based in maritime, coastal, or inland areas, so they can together support healthy rivers and oceans.

WHAT IS BLUE CITIZENSHIP? INTEGRATING THE OCEAN INTO DEMOCRATIC PROCESSES

Blue citizenship is about recognising that our rights and responsibilities also apply to rivers and the ocean.

We all have the right to enjoy a healthy ocean. We also have a duty to protect it.

Blue citizenship brings river and ocean sustainability into democratic life. It ensures that people's voices, values, and concerns regarding the ocean are heard and respected in political debates and decision-making.

Being a blue citizen extends beyond individual choices, such as reducing plastic use or purchasing sustainable products. It is about active civic engagement. Blue citizens and elected representatives:

1. Raise awareness of river, coastal and marine challenges and solutions in their communities.
2. Advocate for fair and effective responses.
3. Work to ensure that river and ocean issues are not left at the margins of political debate, but become a regular part of decision-making.

When citizens and elected representatives take part in democratic processes with the clear aim of protecting rivers and the ocean, they act as blue citizens.

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POWERING UP BLUE CITIZENSHIP: POLITICAL ROLES, RESPONSIBILITIES AND OPPORTUNITIES FOR BLUER DEMOCRATIC PROCESSES

Making sure that people's voices, values and concerns about river and ocean sustainability are heard and respected in democratic institutions and decision-making[2]. This includes simple but powerful actions such as:

- **Voting** for candidates who take river and ocean sustainability seriously, and who support open debate on these challenges and solutions;
- Keeping a close eye on whether decisions that directly or indirectly affect rivers, coasts, marine ecosystems and blue sector development are **transparent, accountable and based on sound knowledge;**
- **Supporting and participating in democratic processes,** including public hearings, debates, participatory governance bodies and citizens' workshops that look at river and ocean sustainability, as these spaces help people learn, share experiences and feed real-life knowledge into decisions;
- **Inviting river and ocean sustainability in public celebrations** organised by (local) authorities and their partners, or organising public celebrations dedicated to rivers and the ocean, including in landlocked cities and territories. Beside enjoyment, this helps embedding rivers and the ocean in cultural and patrimonial values of territories and societies.

Overall, being a Blue Citizen embeds an active civic engagement in democratic processes. When engagement extends beyond awareness, blue citizenship becomes a cornerstone of healthy democratic processes, empowering people and institutions to work together in the service of thriving rivers and oceans. It complements sustainable, responsible choices and practices as a consumer (e.g., prioritising the purchase of products and services with minimal to no impact on ecosystems) and as a professional or corporate shareholder.

Figure 1. Seizing opportunities for bringing citizens on board of the ocean sustainability conversation

2 This complements joining, supporting or contributing to the organisation of civic engagement activities such as: river and marine restoration projects; citizen-science initiatives: awareness-raising of different societal groups; or, adapting (individual and collective) practices to limit pressures on river and marine ecosystems.

OCEAN LITERACY AS AN ENABLER FOR BLUE CITIZENSHIP

Ocean literacy is a fundamental enabler of Blue Citizenship. It lays the foundation for more inclusive and informed democratic engagement, bringing river and ocean sustainability into the heart of civic life and political decision-making. Besides raising awareness on ocean challenges and solutions, ocean literacy needs to evolve to support Blue Citizenship most effectively, widening in particular:

1. Its knowledge base

Ocean literacy should:

1. Present a clear source to sea perspective that shows how inland, coastal and marine areas are connected.

2. Explain how decisions made by democratic institutions in all policy areas, such as transport, energy, housing or communication, can affect rivers and the ocean, even when these areas seem far from the coast.

2. Its target audiences

Ocean literacy work often focuses on schools, young people and the general public. To support blue citizenship, it also needs to:

1. Pay more attention to elected representatives at all levels.

2. Help them understand how river and ocean sustainability links to their mandates and priorities.

3. Offer tools that allow them to bring river and ocean perspectives into different policy arenas, including those that are not usually seen as maritime.

3. Its narratives so these are better rooted in democratic values

Ocean literacy should address not only environmental risks and technical solutions but also social and cultural values. It can:

1. Highlight fairness, equality, dignity, respect and justice as central principles when dealing with river and ocean issues.

2. Show how well-designed ocean policies can bring benefits for people, such as decent jobs, cultural identity, wellbeing and safety.

3. Support stories that connect ocean action with democratic rights and duties, making it clear that everyone has a role to play.

CONCLUSION

For river and ocean sustainability to become an absolute political priority, it must be part of how democracy works every day. Ocean literacy that is grounded in democratic values helps make this possible. It equips citizens and decision makers to balance ecological integrity with social needs in debates and decisions at all levels.

By strengthening blue citizenship, we can build more open, fair and informed democratic processes that support healthy rivers and oceans for present and future generations.